‘Oh, I’m Anuradha,’ she said before leaving.

‘I’m Gunjan . . .’ I replied as she disappeared from sight.

The fall-in took place half an hour later, at the cycle stand in front of the FCM. All of us lined up in attention as the instructor addressed us again. Certain rules pertaining to the academy were relayed to us. ‘You shouldn’t be seen walking, you should wish your seniors, no matter where you are and how many times you see them, you should learn and follow mess etiquette, you should do whatever your seniors ask you to, be at the right place, at the right time and in the right rig . . .’ and so on. With each instruction, the seriousness of the training dawned on all of us. We dispersed for lunch after the address was over. There was an awkward silence all around. After another half hour we were supposed to fall in at the training ground for evening games practice in the games rig.

‘Are they always going to keep us this busy?’ Anuradha asked from behind as she tried to catch up with me as I made my way to the dining table.

‘I guess,’ I replied. ‘My father tells me that every minute inside the academy is calculated. The training never stops.’

‘I don’t mind as long as they give us good food,’ she commented as we lined up with our plates in front of the serving counters.

‘I don’t mind as long as I get enough sleep,’ I said. But I knew I had wished for too much. If there was one thing I was going to be deprived of, it was sleep. Eighteen months of training is not just five hundred and forty days of training, but five hundred and forty nights too. I would learn this soon enough.

The games period started with a three-kilometre run in the squads, where each squad was headed by a physical-training instructor aircraftman. It was followed by intense PT. No games were played that day. After about an hour, we retired to our squadrons, panting and dripping in sweat. ‘This, too, shall pass,’ I said to myself. No sooner had we taken a bath than we were called for a squadron fall-in. The senior-term cadets were waiting for us downstairs as we lined up in the central hall. We somehow knew we were in for some trouble. One of us had forgotten to wish a senior-termer earlier